

6/23 – Intro to Marketing & Digital Marketing

Intro to Marketing

What Is Marketing?

- **Definition** – the process of promoting and communicating the value of a product, service, brand, or idea to a target audience
- At its core, marketing is about:
 - Understanding an audience
 - Solving an audience's problems
 - Building relationships with an audience
 - Driving action from an audience
- Without marketing, people may never know a company or product exists

Why Marketing Matters

- Marketing helps companies build awareness, attract customers, communicate value, build trust and loyalty, stand out from competitors, and support company growth
- Marketing works closely with sales, product, customer success, and leadership
- Most marketing projects involve strategy, creativity, planning, communication, design, collaboration, and problem-solving

Target Audience

- **Definition** – the specific group of people a company wants to reach with its marketing
- Successful marketing starts with understanding the audience: who they are, their needs and challenges, what motivates them, where they spend time
- Audiences may be defined by age, interests, industry, job role, location, behaviors, and goals or challenges
- Marketing is more effective when it feels relevant and personalized

Branding

- **Brand** – how a company is perceived by its audience
- Branding includes: logo, colors, messaging, tone of voice, visual style, reputation, and customer experience
- Strong branding creates recognition and trust

Brand Voice

- **Definition** – the personality and tone a company uses in its communication
- Brand voice can be professional, friendly, educational, playful, inspirational, or bold
- Consistency helps audiences recognize and connect with a brand
- Brand voice must remain consistent across all channels and content types

Buyer Personas

- **Definition** – a fictional representation of an ideal customer based on their role, responsibilities, goals, challenges, and needs
- Buyer personas help marketers understand who they are trying to reach and create messaging that feels relevant and valuable
- Companies use buyer personas to: understand their audience, create relevant marketing messages, develop products that solve real problems, choose the right channels, and improve campaign effectiveness
- **Key questions for building a persona:**

- Responsibilities: What is their role? What teams do they work with? What decisions do they make?
- Goals: What does success look like? What are they measured on? What would make their job easier?
- Challenges: What frustrations do they experience? What tasks take too much time? What resources are limited?
- Product connection: What problem does our product solve? How does it make their job easier? Why would they care?
- **Persona elements:** photo, name, title, job responsibilities, goals, challenges, perceived barriers, decision criteria

The Customer Journey

- **Definition** – the path people take from first learning about a company to eventually taking action
- Common stages: Awareness → Interest → Consideration → Decision → Loyalty/Engagement
- Marketing helps guide audiences through each stage

Marketing Campaigns

- **Definition** – a coordinated effort designed to achieve a specific goal
- Campaign goals may include: launching a product, promoting an event, increasing awareness, generating leads, driving registrations or sales
- Campaigns often use multiple marketing channels together

Day 1 Assignment

- Create branding and buyer personas for the intern product, including:
 - 1 brand board (colors, logo, fonts, visual style)
 - 8 buyer persona profiles – one per intern, each covering a different higher ed role (IT, Institutional Research, Financial Aid, Admissions, Enrollment, Finance, Advancement, HR)

Digital Marketing

What Is Digital Marketing?

- **Definition** – the use of online platforms and digital channels to promote products, services, brands, or campaigns
- Common digital channels: websites, email, social media, search engines, online advertising, video and content platforms

Why Digital Marketing Matters

- Helps companies reach large audiences, target specific groups, build awareness online, drive website traffic, generate leads and sales, measure campaign performance, and communicate quickly and consistently

Multi-Channel Marketing

- **Definition** – using several platforms together to support one campaign or message
- Example – a webinar campaign may include: social media posts, email reminders, a registration landing page, follow-up emails, and blog promotion
- Different channels serve different goals: social media for engagement and awareness, email for direct communication, websites for information and conversions, search engines for visibility, digital ads for targeted promotion

Digital Content Types

- Content is one of the main ways companies communicate online
- Examples: graphics, videos, emails, blogs, ads, landing pages, social posts

Digital Advertising

- Many companies use paid advertising to expand reach and target specific audiences
- Examples: social media ads (eg LinkedIn), Google ads, sponsored content, display/banner ads

Metrics and Analytics

- Digital marketing allows companies to measure performance and results
- Common metrics: website traffic, engagement, clicks, registrations, email opens, conversions, reach and impressions

Day 1 Digital Assignment

- Create paid ads for the intern product, including:
 - 2 LinkedIn paid ad graphics
 - 2 LinkedIn paid ad details (copy, audience targeting, goal)

6/24 – Content Marketing, Email Marketing & Social Media Marketing

Content Marketing

What Is Content Marketing?

- **Definition** – the creation and sharing of valuable, relevant, and consistent content to attract, educate, engage, and build trust with a target audience
- Content marketing helps companies build credibility and trust, educate audiences, increase brand awareness, support sales goals, drive website traffic, improve engagement, and position themselves as industry experts

Types of Content

- Blogs, case studies, videos, social media posts, newsletters, webinars, infographics, guides/resources, testimonials, product announcements
- **Educational content** – designed to inform, teach, or provide value; examples: tips, guides, industry trends, how-to content
- **Promotional content** – designed to encourage action or awareness around a product, service, or event; examples: product launches, event registration, service offerings, announcements

Content Strategy

- **Definition** – a planned approach to creating and distributing content that supports business goals and audience needs
- A strategy includes: goals, target audience, content topics, messaging, distribution channels, publishing schedule, and performance tracking

Content Pillars

- **Definition** – the main themes or categories a company consistently creates content around to keep messaging focused and aligned with its brand

- Example pillars: educational, product-focused, customer success stories, industry trends, thought leadership, company culture

Storytelling

- **Definition** – the use of narratives, experiences, and real-world examples to make content more engaging, relatable, and memorable
- Companies use storytelling to highlight customer success, show impact and results, humanize their brand, and create emotional connection

Content Distribution

- Creating content is only part of the process; companies also need a distribution plan
- Distribution channels: emails, social media, website, blogs, case studies, webinars, events, paid ads
- Performance metrics: website traffic, engagement, clicks, downloads, shares, leads generated, time spent on content

Evictions Content Examples

- **Blogs** – "Analytics and Intelligence: From Dashboards to Action"; "Technology Modernization: Cloud, SaaS, and Interoperability"; "Data Privacy Week 2026: Why It Matters for Higher Education"
- **Case studies** – "From Days to Minutes: Transforming Admissions Workflows with Argos"; "Building a Real-Time, Reliable Data Environment with Argos"

Content Assignment

- Create a content marketing campaign for the intern product, including:
 - 1 customer case study
 - 1 industry blog

Email Marketing

What Is Email Marketing?

- **Definition** – direct communication with an audience through email
- Companies use email to: promote products/services, share updates, educate customers, build relationships, drive registrations or sales, and keep audiences engaged
- High ROI marketing channel; provides direct access to audience; enables personalized communication; keeps companies top-of-mind

Types of Marketing Emails

- **Promotional** – sales, product launches, events
- **Educational** – tips, resources, blogs, webinars
- **Relationship building** – newsletters, customer stories, behind-the-scenes content

Building Contact Lists

- Sources: website signups, events/webinars, downloads/resources, newsletter subscriptions, customers/prospects, social media, networking

Audience Segmentation

- **Definition** – dividing an audience into smaller groups based on characteristics so companies can send more relevant and personalized marketing messages tailored to their interests, needs, behaviors, or roles
- Segment by: customer vs prospect, industry, interests, job role, event attendees

- More targeted segments produce more relevant messaging and higher engagement

Email Campaign Strategy

- A campaign is a strategically organized marketing effort around a specific goal, determining audience, messaging, timing, channels, content, and calls to action
- Campaign examples: event promotion, product launch, webinar campaign, customer onboarding
- Strategy components: audience, timing, messaging, design, frequency, goals, CTA

Anatomy of a Good Email

- Subject line, preview text, header image, main message, CTA button, branding, footer
- **Subject line** – critical for open rate; strong examples use specificity, curiosity, or value ("New Webinar Alert: Wait, That's Argos?"; "Hear What Your Peers Are Saying About Evisions Conference") vs weak generic lines ("June Newsletter", "Upcoming Event")
- **CTA (Call to Action)** – the specific action the email drives; examples: Register Now, Learn More, Download Now, Read the Blog, Schedule a Demo

Content Calendars

- A content calendar tracks: send dates, campaign themes, audience, and email purpose
- Helps teams plan campaigns in advance and maintain consistent communication cadence

Metrics and Success

- Key metrics: open rate, click-through rate, conversions, unsubscribes
- Goals: get registrations, increase awareness, drive website traffic, generate leads, nurture relationships, increase conversions

Evisions Email Examples

- **Newsletter** – includes case studies, webinars, on-demand webinars, video testimonials, blogs, events, product updates, user group news
- Other email types: webinar invitations, event promotion, product update announcements, sales and prospecting emails

Email Assignment

- Create an email campaign for the intern product, including:
 - 4-week email calendar
 - 1 case study email
 - 1 product launch email
 - 1 webinar email

Social Media Marketing

What Is Social Media Marketing?

- **Definition** – the use of social platforms to promote a brand, product, service, or message through content designed to engage, inform, entertain, and connect with an audience
- Social media helps companies build brand awareness, reach and grow audiences, engage directly with customers, promote products and events, drive website traffic, build trust and community, and stay visible

Social Media Strategy

- **Definition** – a planned approach to creating and sharing content that supports business goals and connects with a target audience

- A strategy includes: goals, audience, platforms, content types, posting schedule, brand voice, engagement approach, and performance tracking

Content Pillars

- The main topics or themes a company consistently posts about to keep messaging organized, balanced, and aligned with its brand
- Example pillars: educational, promotional, customer stories, behind-the-scenes, industry trends, company culture

Brand Voice on Social Media

- The consistent personality and tone a company uses in its messaging across platforms
- Must match the broader brand voice established across all marketing channels
- Examples: professional, friendly, playful, educational, inspirational

Audience Engagement

- **Definition** – how companies interact and build relationships with their audience through comments, messages, likes, shares, polls, conversations, and community interaction
- Engagement is a two-way activity; companies should respond and participate, not just broadcast

Social Media Calendar

- A planned schedule of content outlining what will be posted, when, and on which platforms
- Helps teams stay organized, maintain consistency, plan campaigns ahead of time, and align messaging across channels

Visual Branding

- **Definition** – the consistent use of colors, fonts, imagery, logos, and design styles to create a recognizable and cohesive brand presence across social platforms
- Consistent visual branding makes a company's posts immediately recognizable in a feed
- Inconsistent visual branding undermines recognition and appears unprofessional

Social Media Campaigns

- **Definition** – a coordinated series of posts and content created around a specific goal, promotion, event, or initiative
- Campaign examples: launch announcements, event promotions, product education, giveaways, brand awareness initiatives

Metrics and Performance

- Common metrics: reach, impressions, engagement, clicks, shares, followers, video views
- Social media supports larger business goals: increasing visibility, building relationships, supporting sales and events, strengthening brand identity, creating community and conversation

Social Media Assignment

- Create a social media strategy and campaign for the intern product, including:
 - 4-week content calendar
 - 1 product launch post
 - 1 case study post
 - 1 webinar post

6/25 – Event Marketing & Website Design

Event Marketing

What Is Event Marketing?

- **Definition** – the planning and promotion of experiences designed to connect people with a brand, product, service, or community through in-person or virtual events
- Event marketing helps companies build relationships and community, increase brand awareness, generate leads and opportunities, educate audiences, create memorable experiences, encourage networking and engagement, and showcase products and expertise

Event Strategy

- Key strategic considerations: budget, expected experience, promotion plan, content and sessions, networking opportunities, and success metrics
- Events are more than schedules and presentations; companies create experiences that make attendees feel engaged, welcomed, and connected
- Event experience includes: branding/theme, atmosphere, activities, networking, food and entertainment, swag, and interactive moments

Understanding the Audience

- Successful events are built around the needs and interests of attendees
- Questions companies ask: Who is attending? What are they hoping to learn or gain? What challenges do they have? What type of experience would engage them?

Sessions and Content

- Event content is one of the biggest drivers of attendance and value
- Session planning includes: educational topics, speakers, workshops, panels, discussions, hands-on learning, and audience engagement
- Even great events need marketing and promotion to attract attendees
- Promotion channels: email campaigns, social media, website landing pages, paid advertising, partnerships, word-of-mouth, internal promotion

Event Timelines and Planning

- Events require detailed organization and planning over time
- Planning includes: registration timelines, marketing schedules, vendor coordination, session deadlines, budget management, logistics, and communication plans

Event Budgeting

- Companies build budgets to understand costs and allocate resources effectively
- Budget categories: venue, food and beverage, swag, travel, speakers, marketing, entertainment, technology, staffing

Sponsorships and Partnerships

- Some events include sponsors or partners that help support the experience financially or through collaboration
- Sponsors may provide: booths, giveaways, presentations, networking activities, financial support

Measuring Event Success

- Companies evaluate events using both data and attendee feedback

- Common metrics: registrations, attendance, engagement, survey feedback, leads generated, social engagement, revenue/opportunities

Event Assignment

- Create a user group conference for the intern product, including:
 - Event name and goals
 - 8 presentation sessions
 - 4 interactive sessions or activations
 - Swag
 - Budget outline
 - Promotion strategy
 - Campaign calendar

Website Design and Strategy

What Is a Website?

- **Definition** – a digital space where companies share information, promote products or services, connect with audiences, and guide visitors to take action
- The first impression people have of a brand; the central hub for all marketing activity
- Websites help companies build credibility and trust, share information, promote products and services, generate leads or sales, support marketing campaigns, provide resources and support, and create a central communication hub

The Goal of a Website

- Common goals: educate visitors, increase awareness, generate registrations or leads, encourage purchases, promote events, provide resources or support
- A good website guides visitors toward a clear next step

User Experience (UX)

- **Definition** – how easy and enjoyable a website is for someone to use
- Good UX includes: easy navigation, clear layout, mobile-friendly design, fast loading speed, organized information, clear calls to action

Website Structure

- Common pages: Homepage, About, Products and/or Services, Contact, Resources (Blogs, Case Studies, Webinars), Events, FAQs or Support
- Every page should include a call to action encouraging visitors to take a next step
- CTA examples: Learn More, Register Now, Contact Us, Schedule a Demo, Download the Guide

Homepage Strategy

- A strong homepage should quickly explain: who the company is, what they offer, why it matters, and what action visitors should take

Visual Design and Branding

- Websites should visually match the company's brand and create a consistent experience
- Branding elements: colors, fonts, logos, images, layout, design style
- Consistency helps brands appear more professional and recognizable

Landing Pages

- **Definition** – a focused webpage designed around one specific goal or campaign

- Examples: event registration, webinar registration, product launch
- Landing pages remove distractions and focus the visitor on a single action

Search Engine Optimization (SEO)

- **Definition** – practices that help websites appear in search engine results like Google
- SEO includes: keywords, headlines, website structure, quality content, user experience
- Better SEO helps more people find a website organically without paid advertising

Measuring Website Performance

- Companies track website performance to understand how visitors interact with their site
- Common metrics: website traffic, time on page, clicks, conversions, form submissions, bounce rate
- Data helps companies improve their websites over time

Website Assignment

- Create a website for the intern product, including:
 - Homepage
 - About page
 - Product landing page
 - CTAs throughout

6/26 – Business, Communications, Philanthropy & Meeting with Josh

Business – Revenue, Sales, and Career Development

Speaker: Brian, Chief Revenue Officer (13 years at Evisions)

What Revenue Is Really About

- Revenue comes from creating value – solving a real problem for a customer in a way that is worth what they are asked to pay
- The gap between a customer's status quo and where your product can take them determines whether a purchase happens; if the perceived gap is too small, the sale does not close
- After the purchase, continuing to deliver perceived value is what drives renewals; clients who do not see ongoing value will not renew
- Evisions has 97.5% client retention and 60% of the client base has been customers for over 10 years – both elite metrics that reflect the quality of every team across the organization

How Evisions Creates Revenue

- **New software sales** – marketing creates awareness; sales discovers the client's problem and demonstrates fit; the bell rings when a deal closes
- **Renewals** – customer success and professional services work together to ensure clients extract value from the product; client partners check in continuously, enable new departments, and build strong relationships so clients want to stay despite constant outreach from competitors
- **Professional services bookings** – training, remote development (building reports and data blocks for clients), and consulting (prioritizing reporting strategy, security rollouts, etc)
- **Partnerships** – Ellucian (Banner/Colleague) resells Argos to their client base; additional partners in the Middle East and Latin America; Infope Learning is a newer partner that can also sell Argos and whose data lake Evisions can sell

What Clients in Higher Ed Are Really Buying

- Clients are not buying software – they are buying outcomes: time saved, clarity gained, better student retention data, more efficient donor and alumni campaigns
- Higher ed value drivers: attracting students, retaining students who are already enrolled, raising funds from donors and alumni, and saving money or staff time
- Decisions are more likely when the client feels good about the risk involved and the resources required relative to the expected outcomes

Consultative vs Transactional Selling

- The stereotype of salespeople who talk constantly is the opposite of how effective sellers operate; talking too much is one of the hardest habits to overcome and the least effective approach
- Effective selling requires asking great questions and being genuinely curious; getting deep enough into an industry so that you can respectfully challenge a client's current approach and tell them things they did not know about their own problems
- When clients stop seeing you as a salesperson and start seeing you as a consultant solving real problems, you win deals that transactional reps do not
- Higher ed clients move slowly and do not respond well to urgency or pressure; the best reps act as project managers, helping clients work backward from a target go-live date to figure out what needs to happen by when
- The higher ed space is small – the same people, companies, and clients move around; integrity and reputation follow you; never make something up or burn a bridge

Brian's Career Path and Key Lessons

- Started at Enterprise Rent-A-Car (excellent general business training – ran a P&L, managed people, handled customers); moved to commercial real estate (assistant GM of a large mall, leasing); recruited to a senior executive role at Taubman Company (leasing for five major malls) at age 28 – was fired because leadership was entirely self-focused rather than team-focused
- Went from executive to selling Toshiba copiers on 8 Mile Road in Detroit; cold-walked businesses in eight-degree weather; sold the most Toshiba copiers of any first-year rep in the state of Michigan through pure grind
- Got recruited to iDashboards (software company in Troy, Michigan) selling to higher ed; hard work plus studying psychology of sales and framing drove close rate from 25% to 50–60%, making him the top rep of 35 for two and a half years
- Joined Evisions (already knew the higher ed space and Argos); promoted to VP of Sales in 2017, then Chief Revenue Officer in 2021 – this time motivated by helping the team succeed rather than personal ambition; that shift in mindset made all the difference
- **Core lesson on leadership** – people see through leaders who are in it for themselves; if you seek a leadership role for the title or perks, you will fail; if you seek it because you genuinely want to help the people around you succeed, it works

What Brian Looks for When Hiring

- Uses the KAM triangle: **Knowledge** (do they have what the role requires, or can they acquire it?), **Ability** (can you see them actually doing the job?), **Motivation** (do they genuinely care?)
- **Curiosity** – are they always looking to get better, asking questions, learning?
- **Coachability** – can they take feedback without being defensive? Especially important early in a career; does not require suppressing new ideas, but does require being open when per-

formance needs to improve

- **Emotional intelligence** – self-awareness, self-control, relationship management, empathy; recommended reading: *Emotional Intelligence 2.0* by Travis Bradbury (includes a self-assessment); EQ can be improved and has a significant impact on both career and personal life
- **Ownership** – people who own their outcomes and proactively flag when something is not going well (along with a plan to address it) get noticed and trusted; hiding problems does not
- **Integrity** – do what you say you will do; be direct and honest even when it is uncomfortable; people will respect directness even if they do not always like the message; do not lie or beat around the bush
- On job applications: if a role interests you and the requirements are not wildly beyond your level, apply anyway; motivated candidates with the right ability are often chosen over candidates who technically check more boxes

Sales Is Universal – Not Just for Sales Roles

- Everyone sells in some form: engineers negotiate for headcount, marketers pitch campaigns to leadership, individuals advocate for their own career growth
- Studying psychology, persuasion, and negotiation is useful regardless of career path; recommended reading: *Conversations That Win the Complex Sale* (directly applicable to positioning and messaging in any role; led to a 150% income increase after Brian applied its concepts)
- AI at Evisions: used for quick account research before client meetings, analyzing call transcripts via Momentum to surface client pain points in real time, demand-gen outreach campaigns that learn what messaging works over time, and SQL conversion work in professional services; Brian's preferred framing is always using AI toward a specific outcome rather than discussing it in the abstract

First Six Months Matter Most

- In a new client relationship, the first six months set the narrative for the entire account
- Quick wins are critical: getting the starter pack running, getting the right reports in front of executives and stakeholders, making champions of the product look good internally
- The person who championed a purchase bears political risk if the implementation goes poorly; PS and customer success protecting that champion is a major part of delivering value

Communications – Interview Skills and Career Conversations

Speaker: Stewart

Running the Conversation in an Interview

- The best candidates do not wait passively to be asked questions – they actively try to run the conversation and demonstrate they are good at having it
- Most interviewers are themselves more comfortable when the candidate takes natural ownership of the flow; this reads as confidence and social intelligence
- Making it feel like a real conversation rather than a formal interrogation requires deliberate technique, not just a relaxed attitude

Strategic Rapport – Finding the Subject

- Every person has a subject – something they are so fascinated by that they cannot help but talk about it when asked; finding that subject and asking about it before getting into formal interview content creates an immediate positive dynamic
- Research the interviewer in advance (LinkedIn, social media, any public profiles) to iden-

tify their subject – family, sports, hobbies, professional passions – and open with a genuine question about it

- Example: before a 15-minute prep call with a senior Google executive, Stewart found he was a lifelong Chelsea fan during a high-profile signing period; he opened with a question about it, and the exec talked for seven minutes without prompting – the relationship was established before any formal content began
- The technique works across contexts: a barbecue enthusiast, a soccer fan, a runner, a cat owner – people respond to genuine interest in what they care about
- This is not manipulation; it is an application of authentic curiosity, which is also one of the traits hiring managers most value

Common Interview Questions to Prepare

- Tell me about yourself (have a polished elevator pitch ready)
- Why do you want to work here / why this role?
- What do you know about this company?
- What are your strengths and weaknesses?
- Tell me about a time you faced a challenge and how you overcame it
- Tell me about a time you failed
- What makes you qualified for this role over someone else?
- Where do you see yourself in five years / what are your long-term career goals?
- How do you handle pressure or high-stress situations?
- Why are you leaving your current role?
- Do you have any questions for me? (Always have at least two ready)

Questions to Ask the Interviewer

- What do you enjoy most about working here?
- What are the biggest challenges facing the team right now?
- What is the team most excited about right now?
- What does success look like in this role in the first 90 days?
- How would you describe the culture of the team?
- What opportunities are there for growth or professional development?
- What do the best people in this role have in common?
- What is the next step in the process?

Frameworks and Insights

- **Preparation:** know the company, the role, and the interviewer before walking in; preparation is the single biggest driver of confidence, which is itself a major factor in interview performance
- **Stories over generic answers:** have three or four strong stories from real experience ready; test each against multiple likely questions – a single story can often answer “tell me about a challenge,” “tell me about a failure,” and “tell me about a time you led something”
- **Specificity:** generic questions get generic answers; framing your responses with specific examples, outcomes, and numbers is what separates memorable answers from forgettable ones
- **Credibility statement:** a pre-prepared statement that summarizes who you are and why you are a fit, adaptable to at least three common questions (tell me about yourself, why this role, what makes you qualified); worth writing out and practicing until natural
- **Emotional honesty:** it is normal for even a practice interview to feel high-pressure; that pressure is useful – it reveals which answers need more work before it is real
- **Four-step answer process** (to be covered in the next session): a structured approach to

answering behavioral and situational questions clearly and convincingly

Philanthropy

- Intern teams presented their capstone project work; no additional notes

Meeting with Josh – Web Development, Tools, and Career Guidance

One-on-one meeting; Josh is the web developer/designer on the marketing team

Evisions Website Stack

- Company website is hosted on WordPress via WPEngine; WordPress chosen because non-technical team members (marketing, content) need to create and update blog posts and pages without developer involvement – it functions as a content delivery platform
- Theme used is **Divi** – a drag-and-drop WordPress theme that also allows direct CSS and custom code injection; visual front-end editing with module-based layout (columns, sections, custom code blocks); configuration options cover padding, margins, shadows, backgrounds, and more
- Divi allows designers to work visually while still having fine-grained CSS control when needed

AI in Web Development – Josh’s Current Workflow

- **Targeted landing page project** – Josh uses Claude to generate customized landing pages for prospective clients: Claude scrapes a school’s website, pulls relevant institutional details, and generates a page showing how Evisions’ products solve that school’s specific problems, including images pulled from the school’s own site; more personalized than a blanket pitch
- Workflow took approximately one week of iterating before the output was reliable; Josh then created a project instruction file so pages can be duplicated; inputs are now: school name, school URL, product(s) they are interested in, and ERP system (Banner or Colleague)
- Tool split: ChatGPT used as the workhorse for volume page generation (more tokens); Claude used for auditing pages and updating the project construction files (more precise and consistent)
- **Events hub** – built with Claude for a non-technical events coordinator who previously had to enter the same event information into Confluence, Slack, and multiple other places; now a single form-based site (JSON backend) where she enters all details once, and the sales team can look up any event from a central dashboard
- **Branding hub** – a web-based internal resource hub (built to replace an unwieldy Confluence setup) where team members can access logos, color palettes, PowerPoint templates, product messaging, and a custom icon creator; eliminates the constant “can you send me the logo?” requests
- Key insight: AI is excellent for targeted, well-defined tasks and struggles with broad, loosely-defined ones; human review is essential because AI makes mistakes; the developer role is shifting toward prompt engineering, QA, and iteration rather than writing code from scratch

Tools and Technologies to Know

- **WordPress** – industry-standard CMS; good to understand even if not actively building on it, since many companies use it; combined with Divi it covers most marketing website needs
- **Divi** – WordPress theme for drag-and-drop visual site building with CSS control; widely used at agencies and in-house marketing teams
- **Figma** – UI/UX design and prototyping tool; used to design page layouts, wireframes, and workflow diagrams before building; the Evisions UX team uses it extensively; worthwhile to learn, has a learning curve

- **Gamma.app** – AI-powered tool for generating websites, presentations, and pitch decks from content prompts; good for mockups and quick prototypes; useful for showing stakeholders a concept before building; free tier available
- **Tailwind CSS** – utility-first CSS framework; widely adopted; Claude-generated front-end code frequently uses Tailwind; learning it gives you context for AI-generated output and speeds up styling significantly
- **HTML, CSS, JavaScript** – the core foundation; learn these first before any framework; understanding the fundamentals makes every framework and AI-generated code easier to read, correct, and extend
- **React.js** – popular JavaScript framework for building component-based UIs; good to know, but frameworks come and go; having the HTML/CSS/JS foundation means picking up any framework is mostly a syntax change
- **AI tools (Claude, ChatGPT)** – use AI for project ideas when stuck, for generating initial code, and for debugging; always review and understand the output; use projects/instruction files to maintain consistency across sessions

Front End vs Back End

- Josh started as a front-end developer and naturally expanded into full stack as projects required database integration
- Back-end fundamentals (hosting, domain pointing, basic database implementation) are relatively approachable; managed hosting platforms handle most infrastructure complexity
- Deep back-end work (optimizing databases for high traffic, complex SQL, server performance) only becomes necessary for large-scale applications – not a barrier for early portfolio projects
- Recommendation: start with front-end, build things, and learn back-end concepts as they naturally become necessary
- For small internal tools, a JSON file can serve as a lightweight database without needing a full relational database setup

Portfolio and Project Guidance

- **Build projects around real problems** – the best projects come from observing an inefficiency and building something that solves it; both the events hub and the branding hub came from noticing pain points in the team’s workflow
- **Target a company or industry** – if there is a type of company or role you want, build something that solves a problem that company faces; it is a direct signal of fit and initiative
- **Use AI for ideas and unblocking** – AI is useful for overcoming writer’s block and brainstorming project concepts, not just for generating code; describe a problem space and ask for project ideas
- **Example project idea** – a tool related to the job search process itself (filtering, tracking applications, surfacing relevant postings) is both personally useful and technically demonstrable; AI resume filtering tools used by large employers may inadvertently deprioritize candidates across multiple applications based on early low-quality submissions – a tool that addresses this gap could be meaningful
- **Interest-driven projects** – building something around a personal interest (games, music, sports) teaches the same skills and is easier to sustain; Josh started a Path of Exile crafting guide site because the game lacked a clear resource
- Use Claude/ChatGPT projects with instruction files to maintain context and consistency as a project grows

AI and the Evolving Role of Developers

- Most developers are no longer writing code purely from scratch; AI handles the initial generation and developers focus on reviewing, iterating, and catching errors
- The human loop remains essential – AI makes mistakes, and someone with coding knowledge is required to catch and correct them; blind trust in AI output is a liability
- Public sentiment is increasingly skeptical of AI replacing human interaction; the demand for the human element in customer-facing and creative work remains strong
- The tradeoff is real: AI speeds up repetitive work but can reduce the creative problem-solving that many developers find most satisfying; worth being aware of as a career consideration
- Recommendation: learn the fundamentals well enough to understand what AI is doing, so you can evaluate its output critically rather than accepting it uncritically

Shadow Day

- Josh's current primary project is the AI-generated targeted landing page system; shadow time would involve observing the generation workflow, reviewing the instruction files, and seeing the iteration history from initial concept to current state
- Secondary project is designing the event booth – entirely design-driven with no AI component; a different creative mindset from the generation work
- To schedule: coordinate through Teresa